

3.4 Privacy

As defined, privacy is “the freedom from undesirable intrusions and the avoidance of publicity”. The arena of social networking sites that has recently developed actively encourages people to contribute information about themselves to these sites freely. People are providing this information consensually without giving much thought or concern to the issue of privacy. In some cases, members provide information about their friends through testimonials. Personal information is much more open to abuse at present from the malicious elements in society, that is, persons who can potentially abuse the information in user profiles depending on how much information a member is willing to reveal to everyone in their network, or the exposure depth that the member sets their profile viewing to. The aggregation of information gathered in the user profiles makes them extremely valuable and collectable.

One approach to privacy is given in Friendzy’s privacy policy, which says that they may provide personal information directly to a third party in order to facilitate or outsource aspects of their services such as search technology or e-mail support. It is possible that these social networking sites will use user profile information to mine data for targeting specific advertisements. Sites like Friendzy and orkut inquire as to what a person’s favorite books, TV shows and movies are. It is quite possible that these social networking sites will be able to target their intended audience, and even make recommendations and personalization advertising to their members. At present, in the case of orkut and the recently launched personalized search agent from Google, this is perhaps aiming at the specific user and their tastes and interests. orkut’s privacy policy states: “we may share both personally identifiable information about you and aggregate usage information that we collect with Google Inc. and agents of orkut”. When orkut launched in January 2004, their privacy policy originally warned that “by submitting, posting or displaying any materials on or through the orkut.com service, you automatically grant to us a worldwide, nonexclusive, sub-licensable, transferable, royalty-free, perpetual, irrevocable right to copy, distribute, create derivative